Iswaran the Storyteller

The big idea

In **R. K. Laxman's** story, **Iswaran** is the cook and helper of **Mahendra**, a junior supervisor who is sent to remote construction sites. Iswaran's real talent is **storytelling**: he narrates thrilling tales of adventure, horror and ghosts with suspense and drama. One of his ghost stories finally frightens Mahendra away.

Summary

1. **Mahendra**, a bachelor, works for a firm that sends him to faraway construction sites, where he lives in sheds or tents. Iswaran follows him everywhere, cooks well, finds vegetables in the wilderness and makes him comfortable.
2. Every night Iswaran tells **stories**, which are better than television. He borrows from the Tamil thrillers he reads, building suspense with pauses, gestures and facial expressions.
3. **The elephant story**: Iswaran claims that when he was a schoolboy, a wild **tusker** escaped from the **timber yard** and ran through the town. While everyone fled, he picked up a **stick** and struck the elephant on its **third toenail**; the elephant collapsed. Mahendra is sceptical but enjoys the tale.
4. Iswaran says the region where they now live is **haunted**, as the site was once a **burial ground**. He describes a **female ghost**, a skeleton carrying a **foetus** in her arms, who appears on full-moon nights. Mahendra laughs at this as nonsense.
5. One full-moon night, Mahendra wakes to a moaning sound and sees a dark, cloud-like shape near his window, holding a bundle. Terrified, he hides and sweats.
6. The next morning he decides to **leave the haunted place**, and Iswaran's storytelling has won.

Characters

- **Iswaran**: resourceful, cheerful, a cook and helper with a vivid imagination; a born storyteller who exaggerates.
- **Mahendra**: practical, rational, mild-tempered; he enjoys stories but believes he is too sensible to fear ghosts, until the end.

Themes

- **Power of imagination and storytelling**.
- **Suspense and suggestion** can affect even rational minds.
- Humour in human fear.

IS THE GHOST REAL?

The story never confirms a real ghost. What Mahendra "sees" may be the effect of Iswaran's suggestion on his mind. Write this ambiguity in answers.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

How did Iswaran make his stories interesting? Narrate the elephant episode. Why did Mahendra leave? What qualities made Iswaran an asset to Mahendra?

Quick recap

- Mahendra: junior supervisor at remote sites; Iswaran: cook and storyteller.
- Elephant tale (stick on third toenail) and female ghost tale.
- Ghost story scares Mahendra; he leaves.

Practice questions

1. Who wrote "Iswaran the Storyteller"?
   (a) Ruskin Bond (b) Mulk Raj Anand (c) R. K. Laxman (d) Vikram Seth
2. What was Mahendra's job?
   (a) A cook (b) A junior supervisor at construction sites (c) A forest officer (d) A schoolteacher
3. Iswaran's stories were influenced by
   (a) English novels (b) Films (c) Tamil thrillers he read (d) His grandfather's diaries
4. According to Iswaran, how did he stop the elephant?
   (a) He threw stones at it (b) He offered it sugarcane (c) He shouted loudly (d) He hit it on the third toenail with a stick
5. What was the ghost Iswaran described?
   (a) A female ghost carrying a foetus (b) A headless horseman (c) A child who cried at night (d) An old man with a lamp
6. What did Mahendra decide after the full-moon night?
   (a) To dismiss Iswaran (b) To call a priest (c) To leave the haunted place (d) To write a book of ghost stories
7. How did Iswaran make his stories interesting?

Answers: 1. c 2. b 3. c 4. d 5. a 6. c 7. see notes